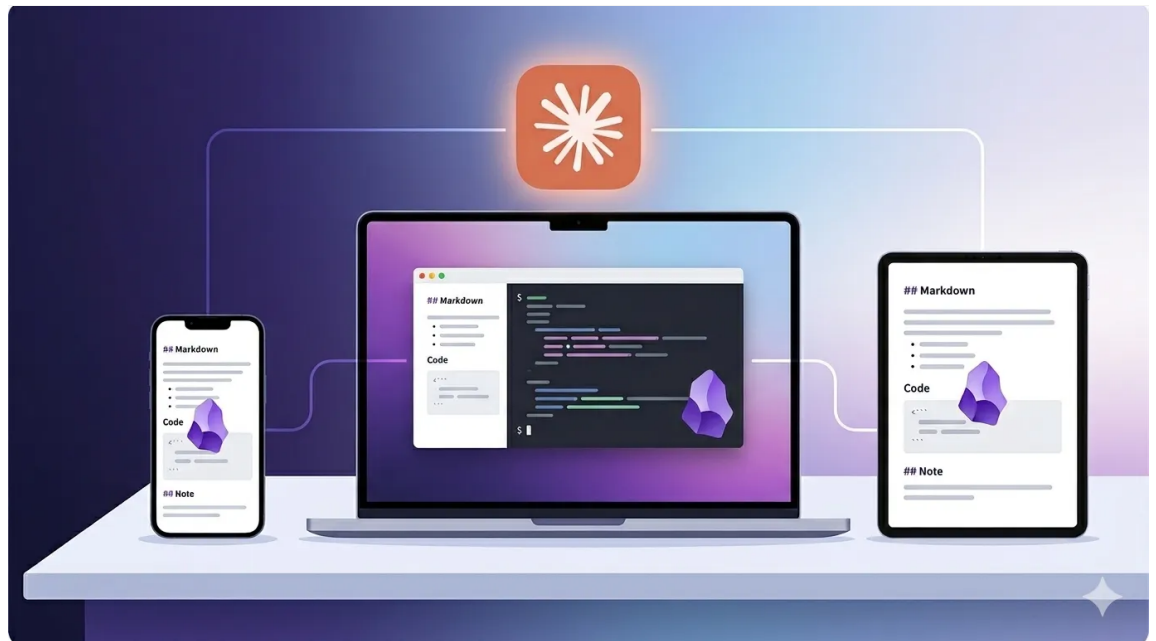


Towards AI



Source: AI generated Image by the author

Member-only story

Supercharge Your Notes: Obsidian + iCloud + an AI That Actually Lives in Your Notes



Swapnil Tiwari

Follow

7 min read · Apr 9, 2026



82



3



There are two types of note-takers. The ones who are perfectly happy with Apple Notes or Google Keep, and the ones who have tried Notion, Roam, Obsidian, Bear, plain text in Dropbox, and are still not satisfied.

I'm the second type. I've rage-quit more note-taking apps than I'd like to admit. The problem was always the same: great on desktop, painful on mobile. Or decent on mobile, but completely dumb. No way to actually *do* anything smart with what I wrote.

Then I accidentally stumbled into a setup that made me go “wait, why didn't I do this earlier?”

Obsidian + iCloud + Claude Code. That's it. Three things. And my notes now travel everywhere, sync invisibly, and have an AI that actually reads them. Not a chatbot I copy-paste into. An AI that *lives* inside my notes folder.

Let me walk you through how.

Q: Why not just use Notion / Apple Notes / whatever?

Fair question. Here's the thing, my notes aren't grocery lists. They're architecture decisions, project contexts, daily work logs, half-baked startup ideas that need to marinate for a week. As a developer and builder, I need:

- Markdown. I think in it, I write in it, my tools speak it.
- Offline access. WiFi dies, my brain shouldn't.
- Works on iPhone, iPad, and Mac without me babysitting sync.
- No lock-in. Plain `.md` files I own forever.
- Programmable. I want to automate things, not just type things.

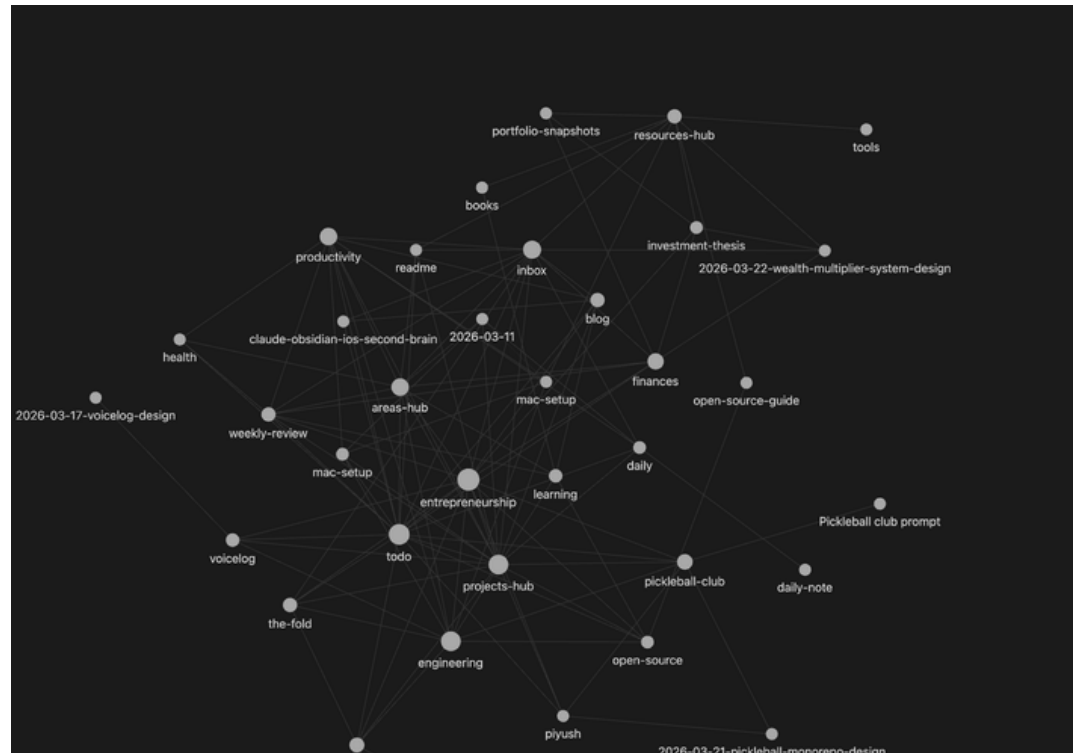
| *Most apps get 2–3 of these right. Getting all 5? That's where it gets fun.*

Enter Obsidian

If you haven't used Obsidian yet, go check it out. It's a markdown editor that treats a folder of `.md` files as a knowledge graph. You link notes with

wikilinks (`[[like this]]`), there are plugins for everything, and your data is just files on disk. No proprietary database, no cloud dependency.

I run one vault that does everything. Daily journal (one file per day), project tracking (one file per project), a quick-capture inbox, and a knowledge base for reference stuff. One vault, one folder, everything connected.



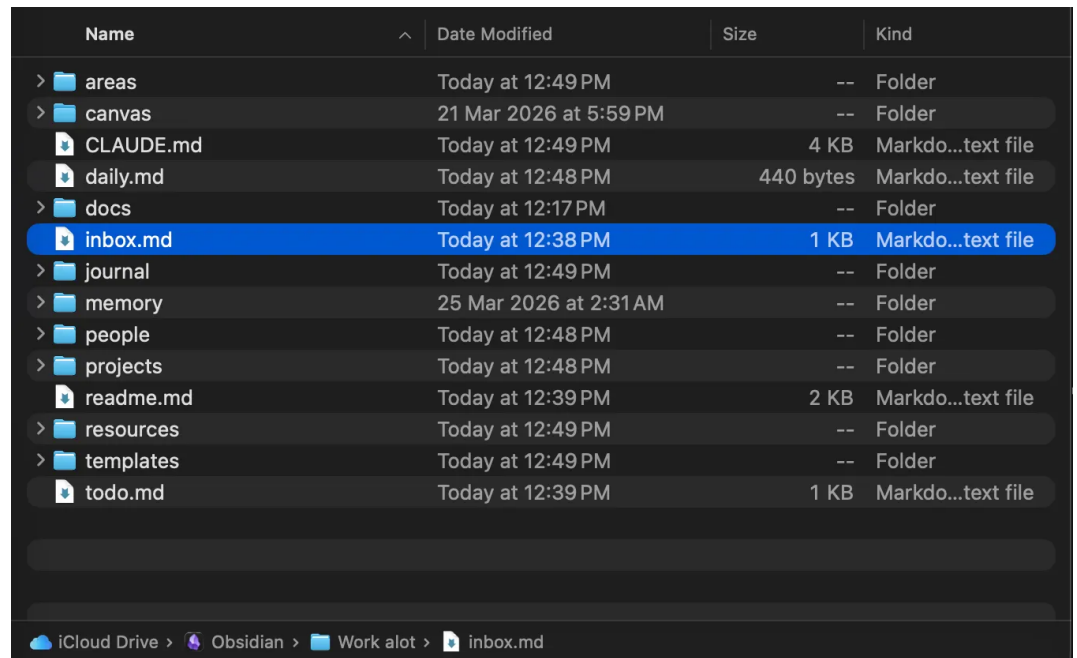
My vault's graph view: every note connected through wikilinks (Source: Image by the author)

The beautiful part: Obsidian **doesn't care** *where* the folder lives. It just reads files. Remember this, it becomes important in a second.

Enter iCloud Drive (the invisible sync layer)

Here's the trick. My Obsidian vault lives **inside** iCloud Drive:

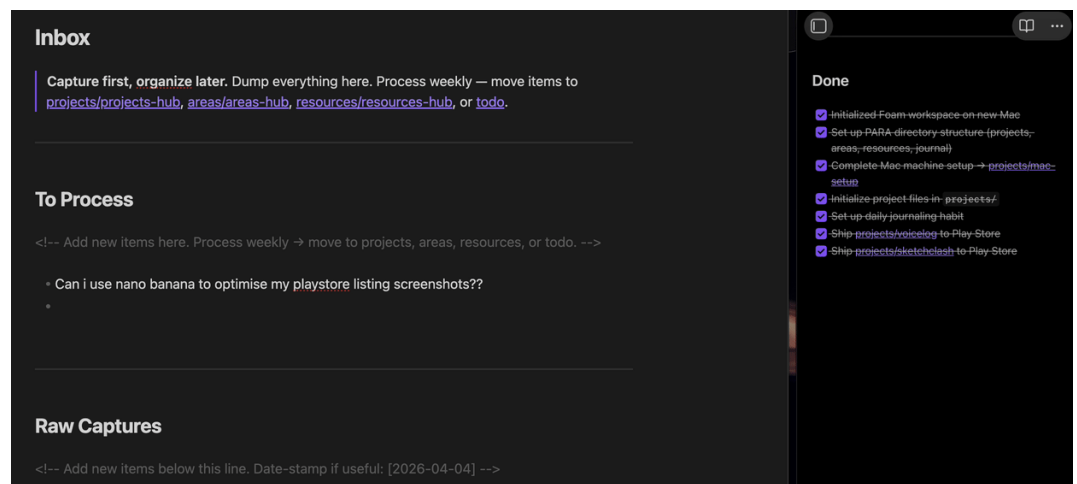
```
~/Library/Mobile Documents/iCloud~md~obsidian/Documents/Workalot
```



The vault lives in iCloud Drive. Ugly path, beautiful sync. (Source: Image by the author)

Yeah that path is ugly. You set it once and never look at it again. What happens after:

- On Mac, Obsidian opens the vault natively. Full experience.
- On iPhone/iPad, Obsidian's mobile app reads from the exact same iCloud location. Same vault, same notes. Zero config.
- iCloud syncs everything silently. No git conflicts, no manual push/pull.



Type on iPhone, see it on Mac. No manual sync. (Source: GIF by the author)

I capture an idea on my phone while walking. By the time I sit at my Mac, it's already there. No "let me sync real quick." It just works.

Cannot stress this enough, iCloud sync with Obsidian is one of those invisible things that Apple gets right when you just let it do its thing.

Enter Claude Code (this is where it gets crazy)

Okay so here's where this setup goes from "nice note system" to something I genuinely can't work without now.

Claude Code is Anthropic's CLI tool. It runs in your terminal and has full access to your local filesystem. You point it at your Obsidian vault folder and suddenly you have an AI that can:

- Read your *entire* knowledge base, not just one note, but the connections between them
- Create and edit notes following your exact conventions (wikilinks, tags, templates, everything)
- Remember your projects and preferences across sessions (yes, persistent memory!)
- Triage your inbox into proper project notes
- Draft content (this blog post? Drafted inside my vault by Claude)

Q: But how is this different from just chatting with ChatGPT or Gemini?

Context. Claude Code has context.

I keep a `CLAUDE.md` file in my vault root. It's basically an instruction manual for the AI. My directory structure, my conventions, what tags I use, how I name files. Claude reads it every session.

```

1  # Worklog - Claude Code Context
2
3  This is Swapnil Tiwari's personal Foam-based knowledge workspace, running on a new Mac machine. It serves as a second
4  brain for productivity, entrepreneurial ventures, and life management.
5
6  ## Workspace Purpose
7
8  - **Worklog**:: Daily work log, decisions, and context capture
9  - **Entrepreneurial HQ**:: Project tracking, ideas, and execution plans
10 - **Knowledge Base**:: Resources, learnings, and reference material
11 - **Life OS**:: Goals, habits, and area reviews
12
13 ## Directory Structure
14
15 ```
16 | journal/      # Daily notes (YYYY-MM-DD.md), Foam daily notes
17 | projects/    # Active projects - one file per project
18 | areas/       # Ongoing areas of responsibility
19 | resources/   # Reference, research, saved knowledge
20 | templates/  # Foam note templates
21 | inbox.md     # Quick capture - process regularly
22 | todo.md     # Task hub - linked from project/area files
23 | .claude/agents/ # Claude agent prompts for this workspace
24 ```
25
26 ## Conventions
27
28 - **Wikilinks**:: Use `[[note-name]]` to link between notes. You, 3 weeks ago • migration to obsidian
29 - **Date format**:: ISO 8601 - `YYYY-MM-DD`
30 - **Journal**:: One file per day in `journal/`, named `YYYY-MM-DD.md`
31 - **Projects**:: One file per project in `projects/`, follow `templates/project.md`
32 - **Theme tags**:: (for graph view clustering): `#theme/projects`, `#theme/finances`, `#theme/people`, `#theme/
33 engineering`, `#theme/health`, `#theme/productivity`, `#theme/learning`, `#theme/journal`
34 - **Status tags**:: `#status/active`, `#status/paused`, `#status/done`, `#status/idea`
35 - **Topic tags**:: `#android`, `#kotlin`, `#react-native`, `#writing`, `#collaboration`
36 - **Inbox tags**:: `#idea`, `#blog-idea`
37 - **No type tags**:: - directory structure implies type (no `#project`, `#area`, `#resource`, etc.)
38
39 ## Key Files

```

My CLAUDE.md — the instruction manual Claude reads every session.(Source: GIF by the author)

It's not starting from zero. It knows my stuff. That's the difference.

The iOS workflow (and why it matters so much)

Here's where the three pieces come together and it really clicks.

The best note system is the one you actually use when an idea hits at a random moment. With Obsidian on my iPhone and iCloud handling sync, I capture things all day:

- Jot priorities into my daily note in the morning
- Dump random ideas into `inbox.md` during commute
- Review project status while waiting in line for coffee

Then I sit down at my Mac, open terminal, fire up Claude Code:

Then I sit down at my Mac, open terminal, fire up Claude Code and run

one command:

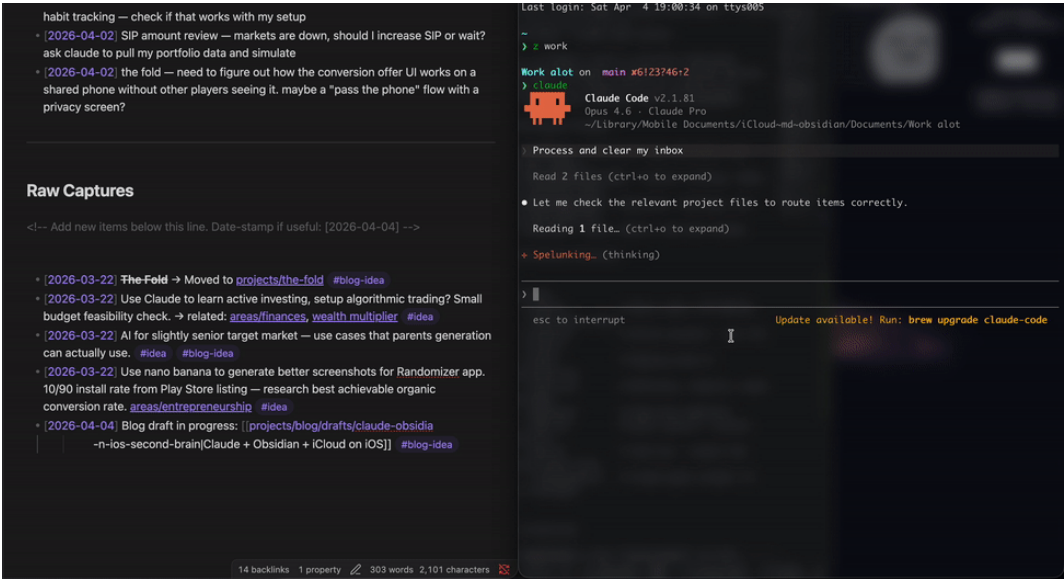
```
/process-inbox
```

That's a custom slash command I wrote (it lives in `.claude/commands/process-inbox.md` inside the vault). When I run it, Claude walks through my `inbox.md` one item at a time, asks me clarifying questions where the intent isn't obvious, and routes each one to the right place:

- Half-baked thought → `resources/`
- Real project → new file in `projects/` with a full plan
- Task → appended to `todo.md`
- Trash → deleted (with my ok)

I review, approve, done. My inbox goes to zero and every idea has a home. The reason it works so well is that it's interactive, not fire-and-forget, Claude stops and asks "is this actionable now, or someday/maybe?" instead of guessing and making a mess of my vault.

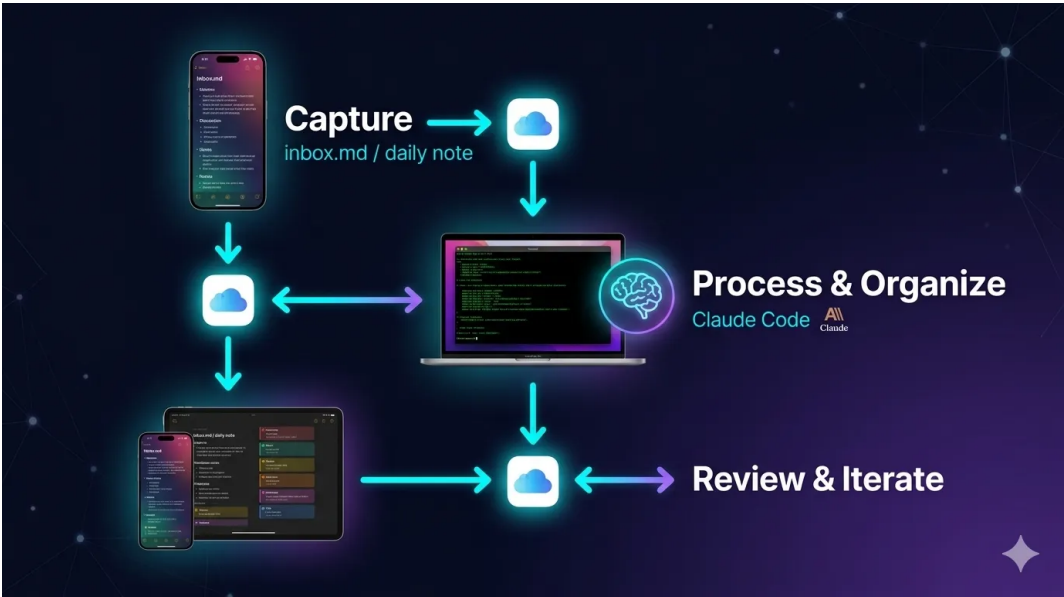
The beautiful part: slash commands in Claude Code are just markdown files. You write the instructions once, in plain English, and they become reusable workflows. No plugins, no config UI, just `.md` files that Claude reads.



“Process my inbox.” Claude reads my captures and organizes them into projects. (Source: GIF by the author)

“Help me outline the architecture for X.”

Claude reads my project files, pulls context from decisions I logged weeks ago, and drafts something that’s actually informed by my own notes. Not generic AI output. Output that knows what I’ve been building.



(Source: Image by the author, generated by AI)

Mobile for capture and review. Desktop for AI processing and creation. Each device does what it's good at. No API keys on your phone. No local LLM on your iPad. The intelligence lives on your Mac, and iCloud carries the results everywhere.

Bonus: Setting this up yourself

If you want to try this, here's the quick version:

1. Create your Obsidian vault inside iCloud Drive. Make sure it syncs between your devices before doing anything else. This is the foundation.
2. Keep the vault structure simple. I use `journal/`, `projects/`, `areas/`, `resources/`, `templates/`, and an `inbox.md`. That's it. Don't over-engineer this. The simplicity is why it works on a phone.
3. Install Claude Code on your Mac. Point it at your vault directory.
4. Write a `CLAUDE.md` in your vault root. Document your conventions, directory structure, how you like things organized. The better this file, the more useful Claude gets.
5. Set up a `memory/` directory for Claude's persistent memory. It stores context about your projects, decisions, preferences. Future sessions pick up where past ones left off. This is what makes it feel like it actually knows your work.
6. Write your first custom slash command. Drop a markdown file at `.claude/commands/process-inbox.md` (or whatever workflow you want to automate) with plain-English instructions. Next time you open Claude Code in the vault, type `/process-inbox` and watch it run. This is the step that turns the setup from "nice AI assistant" into "personal automation layer."

What I tried and skipped

Obsidian Sync: iCloud does the same thing for free if you're all-Apple. If

you need Android or Windows, pay for Obsidian Sync instead

≡

Medium

🔍 Search

✍ Write

🔔

👤

🏠 Home

📖 Library

👤 Profile

📄 Stories

📊 Stats

👤 Following

🧠 Dev Genius

🐍 Python in Plain En...

📱 The Useful Tech

🤖 Generative AI

🔁 Level Up Coding

🧠 AI Mind

🐍 Top Python Librari...

🌀 Deep concept

🧠 AI Quick Tips

🖥 Realworld AI Use C...

⌵ More

Notion/Roam: Good tools, but my notes are trapped in their format. If Obsidian disappears tomorrow, my .md files still open in any text editor. That matters to me.

Gemini for note processing: They don't have filesystem access. You end up copy-pasting things into a chat window and losing all the structure. Claude Code reads my actual files on disk. That's the difference between "AI that knows about notes" and "AI that lives in your notes."

Wrapping up

Obsidian for the interface. iCloud for sync. Claude Code for intelligence. Three tools, all straightforward, works on every Apple device I own.

If you're a builder who thinks in markdown and lives in the Apple ecosystem, give this a shot. I've been running it for a few months now and I'm still here, which is honestly a record for me and note-taking apps. :)

If you think this can help someone you know, share it! And if you try the setup, drop a comment, I'd love to hear how you tweaked it.

Want the exact CLAUDE.md and /process-inbox slash command I use? Drop a comment or Find me on [LinkedIn](#) or [X/Twitter](#), happy to share the files directly.

Cheers!

If this helped, a clap or two keeps the algorithm happy. :)

AI

Obsidian

Claude Code

Productivity

Second Brain

<https://medium.com/towards-artificial-intelligence/supercharge-your-n...-obsidian-icloud-an-ai-that-actually-lives-in-your-notes-af8413e15313>

Page 10 of 11



Published in Towards AI

Follow

133K followers · Last published just now

We build Enterprise AI. We teach what we learn. Join 100K+ AI practitioners on Towards AI Academy. Free: 6-day Agentic AI Engineering Email Guide: <https://email-course.towardsai.net/>



Written by Swapnil Tiwari

Follow

89 followers · 14 following

Senior Software Engineer | [Booking.com](#)

Responses (3)



Pancake Agree

What are your thoughts?

See all responses